‘Hersch, we know that you are wearing a mask. You put on this happy, jovial face, when we know that you’re not always happy and jovial. Just be yourself.’ As I’ve said, Harmony taught me to be honest with myself, as day in and day out you have to tell your innermost thoughts to people you don’t really know. I’d never before spoken that deeply about what was in my heart and on my mind.

While I learnt some very valuable life lessons at the clinic, I wouldn’t for a moment say that rehab changed the kind of person I am. I still have all this energy – I can’t help it – and I’m still the last one to leave a party. But I now control my alcohol intake. Look, the people at the clinic obviously want you to stop drinking completely, but the thought of not drinking for the rest of my life is quite daunting. Society makes it tough on you. It’s a cultural thing. But I’m a lot more hesitant now before I order my first drink. It’s amazing; it’s such a beautiful space to be in. Before, I didn’t give having a drink a second thought, so going from a balls-to-the-wall attitude to thinking about what I’m about to do is a huge step for me.

Since rehab there have been a couple of occasions where I threw in the kitchen sink and got completely hammered, but I don’t like it much any more. I wake up the next day and I want to kick myself. I ask myself: ‘Why did you do that? You don’t need it. You’ve been down that road so many times, *and* you’re just fucking up your body! I mean, you train so hard … what’s the point of it when you’re going to drink excessively and smoke the odd cigarette?’ So I definitely now think long and hard about my actions. I’ve also noticed that the longer I go without alcohol, the better I feel.

Rehab could not have come at a better time in my life, which had been in a downward spiral over the preceding two years. I had got divorced and experienced various off-the-field incidents. Spending a month in rehab at Harmony Clinic was the most beneficial thing I’d done in 15 years, and it allowed me to pull up the handbrake. Its knock-on effect is that I’m thinking about life a lot more … in fact, I’ve never done so much thinking as I have in the past 20 months.

But, as I’ve said, I haven’t stopped drinking completely, though …

At my first post-rehab Proteas fines meeting, during the ODI series in Australia in January 2009, I downed Energade. Now downing warm Energade isn’t great, I can tell you. Neil McKenzie was the Fines Master, and a couple of fines came my way. It didn’t feel right to be drinking beer with them, given that I had just come out of rehab, but, honestly, the